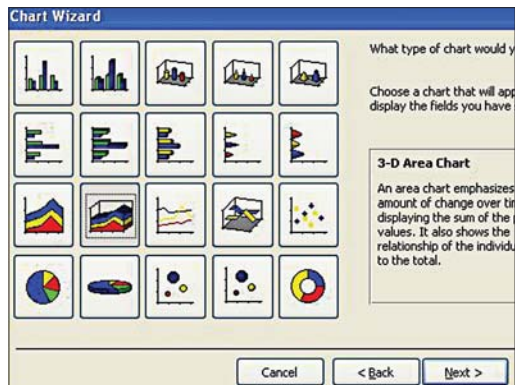


If you don't want to use all the fields or if you want to customise the look and feel of your reports, use the Report Wizard. Follow the instructions and you will get the result. To export reports to other formats like .html or .doc, right-click on the saved report, select Export from the menu, and select the required format. The Chart Wizard has plenty of options (bar chart, column chart, 3D area chart, and more) to visually represent your data.



You get several visual options for your reports

Pages

Imagine a business with a Web site containing data that changes regularly. The data on the Web site needs to be updated regularly. If the data volume is small, the data can be manually updated. But for larger databases, this method is infeasible. Data Access Pages lets you connect your database to the Internet so that any changes made in the database are automatically reflected on your site. You can also edit an existing Web page. Pages are displayed using a combination of technologies like ODBC, Active Server Pages, IIS, and DHTML.



The Page Wizard in Access

Creating a page is simple. As with other data elements in Access you can create pages in design view as well as using a wizard. We recommend the Wizard. Click on New tab in the window and select the type of wizard you want. We selected the Page Wizard. The data sources for Pages are tables or queries. As in

Use Data Access Pages to update your web site every time your database changes

other Wizards, the process of creating a page is the same. The created pages are stored by default in C:\My Documents. If you intend to display the pages over a network, specify a network path.

A note here: pages created by Access are only visible if you use IE 5.0 or above. If you use other browsers such as Firefox or Opera, only the title of the page will be visible, not the data elements. This is a big drawback; those browsers are widely used today.

Macros And Modules

These are advanced features in Access. Both add functionality to your other data items like forms and reports.

Macros trigger specific events when run. For example, if you open a database, a switchboard that enables you to navigate to previously-constructed data elements like reports, forms, etc. can be displayed. This is done by a macro. If there is a Print button in your report or form, it is a macro that does the job when the button is clicked.

Modules are collections of user-defined routines, subroutines, and procedures that automate many tasks. Modules, once written, can be used with any data object in the database. For example, a simple three-line module can be written to launch a Word application from inside Access at the click of a button. You could write a module that can connect Oracle to Access or test whether a string contains alphanumeric characters.

The Big Picture

Microsoft Access gives a lay user the ability to create databases that have the structural robustness of databases built using enterprise level tools like Oracle. It is also extensively used by developers to develop database models for rapid application development. Access is packaged with an eclectic collection of templates; templates are also available online, from Microsoft's Web site and also elsewhere. A sample database called Northwind comes with every copy of Access. This database illustrates all the functionalities of Access. Take some time to go through the Northwind database. Believe us, it will be a wise investment.

After you are comfortable with the basics of Access, you will be able to explore features such as adding security options, using macros to automate tasks, and more. You could also look up sample databases on the Web (www.data-baseanswers.org/data_models is a very good repository) to see how they are structured.

There are similar database management tools, both paid and free, like Lotus Approach and OpenOffice.org Base. Access, however, is most widely used in this segment because of the ubiquity of the Windows / Office duo. The idea of databases and anything associated with them may sound geeky, but as you get more and more comfortable with Access, you will start to discover the sea change Access will bring to the way in which you deal with all those mounds of data. ■

bhaskar_sarma@thinkdigit.com